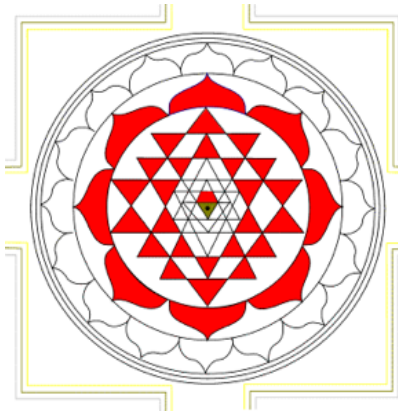




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FROM THE CHIEF EDITOR'S DESK

Hedonistic Semiotics in Arcane Mysticism

Relishing the three rasas or joys leads to deliverance from corporal fetters and absorption into the essential nature i.e the absolute principle. There is an ancient adage in Ayurveda औषधंविषमौषधम् *ousadhamvisamaousadham*. Poison is treated by another poison. The scientific process of making serum by injecting poison into another creature's body and using it as a treatment for poison may not be known to the seers of hoary past but they were acquainted with this phenomena in a mystic way though .

The Gita says that absolute rejection of rasa or sense pleasures can be possible only after the epiphany. This is merely denying something to yourself as if by force whereas the total termination of the impetus as such is not possible. Is moderation a *sine qua non* for the total transcendence which means to go beyond the basic libido drive? Yes, says the conventional metaphysics. No, says the arcane agamas. The state of all pervasiveness of the essential nature in which the enjoying, enjoyments and the enjoyer become inseparable cannot achieve by a premature and abrupt denial of worldly pleasures. One must refine the innate desiring process systematically through *upayas* or mystic knacks. This how the relishing of rasa can conduce to a spontaneous superflow of the ultimate bliss of emancipation *aka* the absolute Brahm. A total subservience to the preceptor is inevitable in this sect called *Rassampraday* by AnantShakti .

The nature and relishing plexuses for their seats and the mode of universal manifestation experienced in those centres in the subtle body are mystic notions so only an accomplished master can help an aspirant with the process. Agamic practices are to be conveyed directly by the preceptor by person to person interactions this explains many variants of apparently the same method.

Coccyx, sacral and naval plexuses are the seats of relishing the mystic bliss that interlaces the process of creation, sustenance and dissolution. There is an axiom in the agamas that the relished and the relisher both is a dichotomy of one singular entity भोक्ता एवभोज्य रूपेणसदासर्वत्रावस्थितः *The process of relishing is the spontaneity of successive divergence which as it were is more oriented to facilitate convergence and en passant the transcendence.* The ultimate objective is to dissolve into what AnantShakti calls, genuine or अकृत्रिम ether. This spontaneous uncreated ether is all pervasive and sentient. Sentience is gradually conditioned as it condenses into grosser manifestations of matter like air, fire, water and earth. The term sentience, ether or चिदाकाश is more commonly used than sentient air or conscious fire or sentient water and earth . The sentience that interlaces the rest of the elementary constituents of the universal manifestation are referred to as *prana* (consciousness in the air), *chidagni* the fire of consciousness in the fire, in water and earth consciousness is pervaded as life sustaining principle and solidity. Unlike conventional Vedanta which rejects

sentient nature of these entities straight away, the agamas opine that Shiva as the ultimate subjective consciousness interlaces all modifications of matter like “sweetness in a lump of jaggery”. This vindicates that the whole is contained in Shiva and Shiva pervades everything within the range of absolute subtlety and absolute grossness. This great dissolution or *mahasamhara* is the absolute dissolution. In this, even the possibility of future germination and sprouting of the divergence is terminated. Owing to its being the fourth state is also called *turiya* (lit. the fourth). The preceding three being *Srishti*, *sthiti* and *samhara*.

This arcane tradition of *rasa* or esoteric mystic relishing is in fact a sect in itself which as we have mentioned earlier are various and multifarious to suit the bend, temperament and competence of an aspirant.

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Food for Health

(Part II)



(Dr. V. Rohil)

The most important elements of '*Food for Health*' are a complete balanced diet, regular exercise, fibre in the diet and above all energy from the sun and occasional fasting. For a sadhak the only thing required is to be near to nature and so natural food products are a kind of essential part of diet of a sadhak. This article is for a common modern man who wants to do sadhana and in the process try to follow various food patterns advised by various paths and schools of yoga, like vigorous fasting, eating only one type of food and so on and thereby overlooking the nutrients which are essential for present day living in today's atmosphere. Such food habits could have been helpful in sadhana in the past but not in the present time where there is so much of pollution everywhere, not only in the environment but also in the foodstuff. Considering the fact that plants used for food are also living beings open to the polluted atmosphere and moreover the fertilizers are all chemicals and not natural compounds. And the carry bags for food stuff are all plastic with a number of toxins in it, so everywhere one finds synthetic and artificial things. I remember 20 years back, a Swami ji used to say that we should eat 'channa' (gram) more as it is grown without artificial fertilizer and he used to recommend only 'gobar' (cow dung) as the perfect fertilizer, but these days even the 'chara' (cattle-food) given to cows and buffaloes is polluted. Hormonal injections are being given to the cattle to increase the milk production. So nothing is natural these days. Therefore even the 'gobar' is polluted! But still the 'gobar' is better than artificial fertilizers to a great extent. So all we can do is to use our common sense and try to search for natural food products and we should try to go near nature as much as possible. That's all we can do in the society. After all we also have to provide milk to our children but when it is not pure then we have to search for the best possible place to get the purest, natural form of it and the same is true with other food materials too. These days in India, rich people are migrating to outskirts of the city and are going to the farm- houses as they can afford but for most of us it is beyond our reach. So we should try to perform our role perfectly i.e. to avoid polluting the atmosphere at least ourselves and try to educate our neighbours too for a greener and purer

atmosphere. Though that is altogether a different subject, but I want to emphasize here that everything is interlinked and it is better late than never to change our habits and habitat.

So far we have reached to a conclusion that we need two things in food for a sadhak, first is a natural food and second is a balanced food with all the nutrients in right proportion. These days most of us are well aware of food and health by reading so many articles in newspapers and so many online internet pages for health. But I will try to touch a few basic points which we overlook sometimes, as we are more concerned with our looks than our inner health which is vital for our life.

The first and the most important point is to avoid certain types of food which are like a poison for any sadhak. Foods to be avoided are junk foods like pizza, burger, samosa, pakora, namkeen, puri, parantha, sweets, jelly, jam, tinned foods. And there are certain kinds of food which can be taken even in excess without any harm, i.e. foods ad lib (not clear) are fruits and salads. I remember one saint had said that fruits are mithais (sweets/candies) given as a gift by God to us. The important part of diet is also the non nutrient parts of diet too which not only provide dietary fibres whose importance will be discussed later but also a source of heterocyclic polyphenols some of which are very powerful antioxidants, much powerful than vitamins in fighting against free radical injuries leading to various diseases like cancer. And also these compounds have a number of antiviral and antibacterial properties apart from anticancer ones and there are so many other beneficial properties for human beings.

All energy in the diet is obtained from three nutrients: Fat, carbohydrate and protein.

Fat or lipid:

Functions: It provides energy, Fat gives energy: 9 kcal/gm of fat. It increases the palatability of food, producing a feeling of satiety. Presence of fat in diet is also required for the absorption of fat-soluble vitamins (Vit. A, D, E and K). Fats in the diet are needed by the body to create prostaglandins and hormones and to provide many other functions. Fats are essential for life. Too much fat is bad for us, but a little is necessary to keep our tissues in good repair, for the manufacturing of hormones and to act as a carrier for some vitamins. Like proteins, fats are made of smaller units, called fatty acids. Most of us think fats are to be avoided in the diet to look slim but this is not true, as fat is required for so many vital functions of our body. One becomes obese due to lack of exercises even if he continues to take average diet, so exercise is more important for staying fit and looking slim than to go on hunger strike with no results. Do you know that a little bit of cholesterol is in fact good for us as we need the protective cholesterol HDL cholesterol to protect our hearts from atherosclerosis? Also cholesterol is required for the synthesis of sex hormones, which are so essential for the reproductive part of our lives. Fats can be either saturated which is bad for health or unsaturated (mono-unsaturated called MUFA or poly-unsaturated called PUFA) which is good for health but it does not mean we can take MUFA or PUFA in excess. A high intake of saturated fat can lead to a raised blood cholesterol level and this has been linked to heart disease. Vegetarian fats tend to be more unsaturated and this is one of the benefits of a vegetarian diet. Mono-unsaturated fats, such as olive oil or peanut oil, are best used for frying as the poly-unsaturated fats, like sunflower or safflower oil are unstable at high temperatures.

Animal fats (including butter and cheese) tend to be more saturated than vegetarian fats. Palm oil and coconut oil though vegetarian fats are exceptions as these are also more saturated. Excess fats in the diet should be avoided and so we should avoid all deep fried food like samosa, pakora, namkeen, puri, parantha etc which are consumed ad lib in India in almost every house. The non vegetarian food even though baked in microwave or tandoors etc have excess of animal fat which is all saturated fat and hence should be avoided.

Recommendation for fat consumption: Daily Recommended Intake of fat should not exceed 1.1 grams/day for women (1.6 for men) and should be less than 30% of total calories with 300 mg of cholesterol per day. So for example if we calculate for 2100 kcal diet for an average built sedentary man that means 700 kcal should be from fat i.e. around 75 to 80 gm of fat (1 gm Fat gives 9 kcal). But it does not mean that we have to eat this much quantity of fat separately because there is always invisible fat in many food items that we consume e.g. if take even low fat milk, it contains in one cup: 8 gm protein, 11 gm carbohydrate and 2.6 gm of fat. So it is suggested that at the most 15 gm of fat should be added to diet in visible form and that should be either MUFA with a little bit of omega fatty acid. 5 gm of desi ghee per day is also good for normal functioning and if we are habitual of it then there is no harm in taking upto 15 gm of desi ghee if one is not leading a sedentary life style. One more thing, do not think PUFA is 100 % safe, no it is not so, as the new research has shown it. So try to go for MUFA and also a little bit of omega fatty acids in to it. MUFA is good but it does not mean we can take it in excess.

Essential fatty acids (EFA) are required in diet and not synthesized by body. EFA are linoleic acid, linolenic acid, arachidonic acid. Deficiency of EFA results in scaly dermatitis, hair loss and poor wound healing. So why not to add a little bit of desi Ghee (made from butter oil) which is proved to be good for health by so many research in India, Pakistan and all over the world. The cholesterol in High density lipoprotein or HDL is protective or good cholesterol and other types of cholesterol are not good for human health though they are required for various functions of the body, these are Low density Lipoprotein or LDL, very low density lipoprotein or VLDL and triglycerides. HDL cholesterol is protective for us and on the contrary LDL cholesterol is dangerous for all of us as it leads to atherosclerosis which is the cause of heart attacks.

Dietary lipids from plant source:

Rich in saturated fatty acids: coconut oil, palm oil

Rich in monounsaturated fatty acids (MUFA): Olive oil, canola oil

Rich in polyunsaturated fatty acids (PUFA): soybean oil, corn oil.

Omega-3 fatty acids: Latest research all over the world has shown that Omega-3 fatty acids, a special type of PUFA are considered essential to human health but they cannot be manufactured by the body. For this reason, Omega-3 fatty acids must be obtained from food. There are 3 types of Omega-3 fatty acids: alpha-linolenic acid(ALA), eicosapentaenoic acid (EPA), and docosahexaenoic acid (DHA). Extensive research indicates Omega-3 fatty acids reduce inflammation and help prevent certain chronic diseases such as heart disease and

arthritis. These essential fatty acids are highly concentrated in the brain and appear to be particularly important for cognitive and behavioral function. In fact, infants who do not get enough Omega-3 fatty acids from their mothers during pregnancy are at risk for developing vision and nerve problems. They play a crucial role in brain function as well as normal growth and development. Omega-3 fatty acids are found mainly in fish and certain plant oils: flaxseed oil, canola (rapeseed) oil, soybean oil, pumpkin seed oil, perilla seed oil, and walnut oil. Foods rich in Omega-3 fatty acids include whole grains, fresh fruits and vegetables, fish, olive oil, garlic, flaxseeds, soybeans, pumpkin seeds, walnuts and wine(I wish if there were some good research on 'Asavas' used so much in Ayurveda like Drakshasava which too have properties of wine and can also be included in lists of many drugs recommended in Allopathy!).

Functions of Omega-3 fatty acids in diet –

- i. It increases HDL cholesterol and decreases triglycerides; walnuts (which are rich in ALA) have been shown to lower total cholesterol and triglycerides in people with high cholesterol. People with diabetes tend to have high triglyceride and low HDL levels. Omega-3 fatty acids in diet can help lower triglycerides and raise HDL.
- ii. It lowers blood pressure significantly in people with hypertension.
- iii. It reduces rate of heart attack: One of the best ways to help prevent and treat heart disease is to eat a low-fat diet and to replace foods rich in saturated and trans-fat with those that are rich in monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fats (including Omega-3 fatty acids), which help prevent and treat atherosclerosis by inhibiting the development of plaque and blood clots, Studies of heart attack survivors have found that daily Omega-3 fatty acids supplements dramatically reduce the risk of death, subsequent heart attacks.
- iv. It helps protect against stroke, depression and children with lower levels of Omega-3 fatty acids demonstrated more learning and behavioral problems (such as temper tantrums and sleep disturbances).
- v. It also reduces tenderness in joints, decreases morning stiffness, and allows for a reduction in the amount of medication needed for people with rheumatoid arthritis. It may also benefit people with other inflammatory disorders, such as osteoarthritis, still research is going on.
- vii. Research has also shown that the Omega-3 fatty acids may decrease inflammation and improve lung function in adults with asthma, Omega-3 fatty acids may inhibit the growth of prostate cancer and also reduce breast and colon cancer rates.

Protein:

Functions: Proteins are the most abundant and functionally diverse molecules in the body. Proteins are the main structural components of the body. Enzymes, immunoglobulins or antibodies, globin in haemoglobin, collagen in bones and several hormones are proteins. Enzymes and hormones regulate metabolism, immunoglobulins provides immunity by destroying bacteria and viruses, contractile proteins in muscle permit movement,

haemoglobin is essential to life and there are so many other functions of proteins. Roughly the recommended daily allowance for protein is 1 gm per kg body weight so a women need about 50g of protein a day (more if pregnant, lactating or very active), men need about 63g (more if very active). There are very good sources of protein for vegetarians also:m

" Pulses: channa or gram, peas, beans, lentils, peanuts, soyabean and soya products.

" Nuts: hazels, brazils, almonds, cashews, walnuts, pine kernels etc.

" Seeds: sesame, pumpkin, sunflower, linseeds.

" Grains/cereals: wheat (in bread, flour, pasta etc), barley, rye, oats, millet, maize (sweetcorn), rice.

" Dairy products: milk, cheese, yoghurt (butter and cream are very poor sources of protein).

Amino acids are the units from which proteins are made. There are 20 different ones . We can make many of them in our bodies by converting other amino acids, but eight cannot be made, they have to be provided in the diet and so they are called essential amino acids. These are Phenylalanine, Valine, Threonine, Tryptophan, Isoleucine, Leucine, Lysine and Methionine, and there are two semi essential amino acids which are required only during the growth period for children and are synthesized by body in adults: Histidiene, Arginine. Single plant foods do not contain all the essential amino acids we need in the right proportions, but when we mix plant foods together, any deficiency in one is cancelled out by any excess in the other. You have may have heard that it is necessary to balance the complementary amino acids in a vegetarian diet. Pulses or beans are lacking in Methionine and cereals are lacking in lysine and tryptophan, so we have to take both pulses or dal and cereals like wheat or rice together so that the amino acids deficient in one will complement the amino acids deficient in the other thus providing all the amino acids to us. And without this knowledge all we Indians are eating 'Khichari' since ages which is the best example of ready made food with all the amino acids in it and so is most famous dal - roti in Indian food.

Consumption of excess proteins- beneficial or harmful:

It is a burning topic these days as to how much protein should be taken. Evidence suggests that excess protein contributes to degenerative diseases. These days you can see most of the adolescent boys and girls, young adults and even middle aged people too are trying to become slim. And for good looks and developing muscles they are going to gyms and taking a lot of protein powders and thus taking excess of protein. So they are flooding their bodies with surplus proteins without thinking that the same internal organs will not be able to cope up with such a heavy load of protein. With a heavy load especially on the liver and kidneys there will be deterioration with time and this will affect the health and age of that person in the long run. With excess protein in diet there will be excessive production and deposition of waste products after catabolism. People are consuming a lot of protein for good figure and shape and thereby accumulating a lot of waste products in their bodies due to which their skin looses texture and charm at a very early age and starts getting wrinkles. You can easily compare a vegetarian person's skin with a non vegetarian person's skin; you will see that the vegetarian persons look much younger as compared to the non vegetarian persons in the same

age group. The skin loses its beauty, charm, smoothness very early in persons taking excess of proteins and you can easily compare skin of Indian people whose protein consumption is low with other parts of world and you will notice this difference clearly. That is also one secret of Indian beauty; it is natural and not artificial. Last but not the least is the allergic reactions due to powdered form of proteins sold in the market, which are mixed with artificial flavors and colors. Now it is for you to decide whether you want to live a short and problematic life with a small peak of a superman or a long healthy active life of a champion. So be natural. Health is wealth.

Other food constituents like carbohydrate, minerals, vitamins, antioxidants and non-nutrient part of diet and also a little bit on fasting and health will be taken in the next part.

Dr Vishwajeet Rohil has taught microbiology in MAMC. Besides being a medical pedagogue he is also an ardent aspirant of metaphysical truth. In this article he has provided tips for the deistic regulation of a spiritual aspirant with scientific vindication of his postulations.

WISDOM FROM RATTLED DRUM OF SHIVA



(Parananda Swami)

अमङ्गलम्॥७॥

शब्दस्पर्शो रूपरसगन्धाश्च अमङ्गलम्।

व्योमादीनां गुणा ह्येते जानीयात् सर्ववस्तुषु॥ 17 ॥

Keywords : Tanmatras, Kalas, Malini , digits, conscious ether , sadakhya , semiotics.

Five elementary constituents of the universal phenomena successively emanate from the unmanifest first in the form of their attributes and consolidate in the form of the five elements. This makes this sutra a sequel to the preceding two Sutras. Before the materialisation of the actual gross phenomena the notion of the universe is conceptual and intellectual which is conceivable in the form of subtle attributes also called तन्मात्रा in Sanskrit. The last nasal letter of each group of Sanskrit consonants comprises this aphorism. The order is dishevelled and the reason behind this is both mystic as well grammatical. The mystic reason as it were encodes the actual order and the key to decode it is the order of meaning is more authentic than the order of recitation .

There are several ways of configuring letters or Matrikas says a commentator on these Karika, alphabet, in groups of five, or the deranged order of *bhutilipi*, a tantrik method of alphabetic arrangement used in invoking the prowess of a mantra . Another order of these Matrika of letters is called *Malini* this follows a dishevelled order of arrangement. One tantrik revelation says that

अभिन्नयोनिमध्येतु नादिफांता कलौयुगे।

The order of alphabet to be followed in the Kali Yuga must be from न to फ .

These aphorisms also follow a specific alphabetic order that becomes evident by eliminating the last semi-consonant of each Sutra and making abbreviations named pratyaharas. Which are 42 variants within the two main pratyaharas i.e. अच् and हल् ? These include all vowels and consonants. After removing the last semivowel of these two major abbreviations one is left with अहं or the supreme self. Letters subjective awareness, self realisation or assimilation into the essential and universal self is the metaphysical fruition of meditation on these aphorisms. They propound the supreme self and at the same time devise means for its realisation. The source of all gnosis subjective or otherwise lies in the pure consciousness which is the substratum of the universal phenomena .The universal phenomena is two fold but before name and form aka word and Meaning begin to separate the transcendental truth prevails in the form of pure consciousness and the only index of that supreme self is अहं। The previous aphorism and the one preceding that has the mystic formula of the order of creation encrypted in them. लण् as separate as per the original beats of the percussion as well as as included in a single aphorism by some unorthodox grammarians comprises the substratum of the entire universal phenomena that emanates from the beats .From another deterministic perspective one might as well construe the purport of this sutra and for that matter that of the entire reticulum of Sutra as inevitable for ascertaining the meaning of the revelations through which we learn the power and process of creation which predates the manifestation of the revelations . So the revelations, as the only testimony of evidence about the phenomena which predates even their manifestation -can be comprehended through a system of grammar which originated from a supra mundane source . The semiotics of shivas rattle drum and the beats which compile a system of grammar for ascertaining the meaning of the revelations can also be evaluated from a realistic standpoint. Panini attributes five principal purposes to this “divine origin “School of Grammar.’ रक्षा protection of the originality of the revelations presumably because owing to the omniscience of their abode they follow a flawless grammatical order . ऊह cogitation, for the elimination of imperfect interpretation and ascertaining the real meaning this system of grammar is inevitable ,आगम propagation of the lineage of knowledge needs a well designed system of descriptive linguistic which is required to retain the same meaning which was purported in the creation for many many eons to come ,लघु is modest and devoid of laborious endeavours. Modest system can serve the purpose better than the one that evolved later on as the sophisticated burden of commentary gloss and notes enhanced the bulk of Panini’s simple and well defined school of grammar . असंदेहः lack of ambiguity a particular word as per the school of mimansa is innately related to its meaning .the grammar of panini which as we already said above is caricatured on the aphorism from shivas rattle drum, is the only authentic system to minimise various renderings which owing to their sectarian presuppositions are badly construed and needless Say because of a faulty understanding of grammar . From a sectarian view there is an ample space for various interpretations ,certain Sutra pertaining to

exceptions and options e.g. बहुलं छदसि। व्यत्ययो बहुलं, can cause misgivings arising from misinterpretation . This school of grammarians is called व्यत्ययवाद the doctrine of options and alternatives; they have a notoriety of construing any word to suit their postulations. for a considerable period prior to the evolution of classical Sanskrit Grammar as a limb of the Vedas served just these purposes .with the volition of classical non Vedic Sanskrit a considerable deal of versatility became inevitable and thus the relevance of synonyms , rhetoric and picturesque expressions .

Those who don't buy this abracadabra stuff can justify this aphoristic foundation of grammar as the means of learning the

Power and process of creation and in a rhetoric way meant to lead to the order of creation itself.

The group of five nasals taken from the last letter of each group of alphabet comprise the seventh aphorism . This is hard to imagine as emanating from from a rattle drum or Damaru aka chod but I heard an expert tabla master play this beat ditto on his percussion .

Nandikeshwar maintains that these denote the five characteristics of the five element in a deranged order though.

Just as the preceding two Sutras are the sources of the five elementary constituents of the universal phenomena viz. Ether air fire water and earth ,this aphorism is the source of their five attributes ,sound, touch ,vision, taste and smell respectively . These are the characteristics of each one of the five elements in a regressing order and that makes them fifteen .five of the earth four of water three of fire two of air and one of ether the sixteenth being perusals or the all pervasive principle himself . Since these relate to the perusals the ultimate principle they are called *kalas* or fractions in the mystic canons.

These *kalas* are believed to be residing in the lunar orb, each one in the digits from the new moon to the full moon.

Sureshwaracharya in his criic of Shankara's commentary has explained this order in his critique of *Panchikaranam* by AdiShankara . *Panchikaranam* is a method of supposition and elimination (अध्यारोपापवाद) in which the objective phenomena is ontologically categorised to facilitate elimination till the pure subjective consciousness remains.

It goes thus, there was the conditioned aspect of the relative Brahman conditioned in existence consciousness and bliss . He pervaded his own maya Shakti which is dormant in a seed form . From that un manifest ether was created ,from their the air ,from air fire and from fire water ,water turned into earth . Ether has one property i.e. sound, air has two i.e. sound and touch, the fire has three properties sound ,touch ,and vision . The water besides these three also has taste and the earth has all five properties viz. smell,taste,vision,touch and sound . These taken together form the fifteen *kalas* which synchronise with fifteen digits of the moon-the sixteenth one is believed to reside in perpetual unison with purusa and therefore referred to as *sodashi*(the sixteenth one)This moon as some mystic have opined is not the

gross satellite that we see in the sky but the mystic *chittachandra* or the moon of consciousness which is meditated upon in the ether of consciousness or *chidakash*. Among the sophisticated tantriks this moon of consciousness is the most adorable object. Kalidasa has compiled a masterpiece named Chidgagan Chandrika (the moonlight in the conscious ether) to extoll this moon of consciousness and her sixteen digits.

Since there is nothing beyond these five elements and their attributes , *kalas* one might as well conclude that what ever is experienced in the phenomenal universal is pervaded by these *kalas*.

Nandikeshwara says that an aspirant should observe only these fifteen characteristics of the five elements in all entities. The order of pervasiveness proceeds from gross and limited towards subtle and extant. Therefore the realm of earth etc. is more and more extant and subtle as we go from the earth to ether. There properties are much more subtle and pervasive than the five elements. This fifteen or sixteen dimensional world view is also interlaced by the conscious principle in the form of fifteen vowels of Sanskrit language which in turn correspond to the fifteen digits of the moon

Within and without . The sixteen digit has been named as *sadakhya* or the ternary digit of the *kalas* of *chitshakti* or fragments of consciousness. A mystic from Persia describes this digit in one of his quatrains.

Ah! The moon of my delight knowest no wain;

The moon in the heaven is rising once again.

The eternal sixteenth digit is latent in rest of the fifteen digits of the moon of delight or *Anandam* which is not different from consciousness. The other fifteen ones are waxing and waning as the heavenly body seen in the gross heavens or sky and as the digits of consciousness configuration within the vishudhi chakra (the mystic cervical plexus in the subtle body) . This mystic secret of the *kalas*, vowels and the fifteen /sixteen sense perceptions is attributed to one lady seer named Lopamudra a princess betrothed to a Brahmin ascetic Agastya. Her lineage of *Shrividya* is still prevalent but pretty rare.

This is the end of the tunnel of perpetually reciprocating objectivity. Each digit and its corresponding perception is presided by a goddess who has her own detailed system of adorations and propitiation through mystic mantras and diagrams. One author of many authentic canons on tantras says that just by knowing about these *nityakalas* an aspirant can cause tumult in their universe. Nandikeshwara has encrypted just these fifteen *kalas* in his *Kashika* based on Seventh Sutram. The deranged order of the first and second nasal of each alphabet group is usually explained by the grammarians as conducive to certain etymological derivations and thus jnanamajnanam, instead of.

Jnanamajnananam. The maxim which have mentioned previously holds good here also. The order of meaning is more authentic than the way it is recited. The Votaries of Panini's school of grammar opine that -इष्टान् वर्णान् भोत्स्यामहे, we know the alphabetic order from the standpoint of utility or implementation or यथाप्रयोजनम् and not यथाक्रमं. This axiom

justifies the deranged order of the letters in a sutra or aphorism .This order has been conceptualised to suit etymological derivation of certain words or to decipher certain aphorisms of grammar. For example four other abbreviations are derived from this sutra owing to its ending with म्. As a result of conventional arrangement of the last nasal syllables of each group of consonants two letters Jn and Ma will have to be excluded from the *yam* pratyahara, according to the Sutras like इमोहस्वादचिडमुणनित्यम् | Moreover all three letters will have to be included in the aphorism इमुट् . The order of arrangement explains ज्जम् .

The pratyahara in the sutra ज्जमन्ताड्डः। In order to exclude “jna” in the pratyahara मय्, the arrangement of letters as per the sutra is inevitable. The mystic import propounded by Nandikeshwara may not stand in face of grammarian justification. The arguments that the order of meaning is more significant than that of recital or owing to its mystic nature the arcane wisdom has been encrypted and only a preceptor can decode the import of these aphorisms -should suffice . The absolute principle getting divergent in the form of *avyakatam* or the unmanifest chaos as ancient Greek thinkers conceptualised it ,further consolidates as *mahat* or the cosmic intelligence . This *mahat* in turn transforms into three types of collective ego viz. Satvik,Rajasekhar and tamasik . From this collective ego, emanates the five tanmatras or the basic perceptions of sound, touch, sight, taste and smell . These five sense perceptions become gross and manifest as the five basic constituents of the universal phenomena viz. ether, air, fire, water and earth. The power and process of the evolution of matter and energy as mind and spirit gets most vivid as we cogitate on the phenomena beginning from the view point of convergence into this mystic penta-syllabic seventh beat of Shiva’s rattledrum. The pure subjective awareness as the source and also the substratum of the entire objective phenomena can be realised if one follows a specific ontological configuration specially suited to converge into the awareness of the universal self and for that matter the essential nature of an aspirant . Like most of the other aphorisms emanating from the beats of the rattle drum of the lord this one too propounds the ultimate dictum of the Vedas i.e. monism directly through this particular beat aka sutra or this is taken as a component of the entire set of fourteen beats .

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ORIGIN OF CULT OF TARA



(Niraj Kumar)

Tara is a pan-Asian Goddess. She is worshipped across East Asia, Southeast Asia and South Asia. The earliest mention of Tara in Buddhist Tantras is found in the Manjusri Mula Kalpa, *Mahavairocana Sutra* and the *Guhyasamaja Tantra*. *Mahavairocana Sutra* was brought to China by Shubhakarsimha(b.637-735 AD) in 716 AD and later propagated by Vajrabodhi(671-741 AD) and his disciple Amoghavajra(705-774 AD) in Ceylon, Java and Tang Court in China. Tara finds her mention as an emanation of Avalokitesvara(Kannon), a popular Bodhisattva of Mahayana in East Asia. In Chapter II of the *Mahavairocana Sutra*, Tara is described sitting on the right side of Avalokitesvara:

“To his right is the holy one, the honored one Tārā, of great renown: With the colors blue and white intermixed, she has the appearance of a mature woman . Clasps her palms together and holds a blue lotus, is encircled with light all-pervading, Glows just like pure gold, smiles, and has fresh white robes;

To the left [of Avalokiteśvara] is Bhṛkuṭī, a rosary of counting beads (mālā) hanging from her hand: With three eyes and wearing her hair in a topknot, her honored figure is as if white, And the light that encircles her has no dominant color, with yellow, red, and white intermingling”.

(p.9, *The Vairocanābhisaṃbodhi Sutra*, Translated from the Chinese (Taishō Volume 18, Number 848) by Rolf W. Giebel, Numata Center for Buddhist Translation and Research 2005).

It is seen that the pair- Tara and Bhrikuti appear together. The mantra of the Tara is Namaḥ samantabuddhānāṃ, karuṇodbhave tāre tāriṇi svāhā. (Homage to all Buddhas! O! You who have risen from compassion! Tārā! Savioreess! svāhā!)(Ibid. p. 60). Though, the seed syllable for Tara had been formulated :

Namaḥ samantabuddhānāṃ, taṃ. (Homage to all Buddhas! Taṃ!)

(Ibid. p.65)

The popular mantra of Tara is Om Tare Tuttare Ture svaha. Clearly during the composition of the Mahavairocana Sutra, this was not formulated and mantra for Tara, one deity among a retinue of deities with Bodhisattava Avalokitesvara, was *Namaḥ samantabuddhānāṃ, tāre tāriṇi karuṇodbhave svāhā*.

Manjusri Mula Kalpa(MMK) is a massive text on Buddhist tantra which spread the cult of the Adi-Buddha(primordial Buddha). In the second chapter of the MMK, the mandala is described wherein Tara is shown in a corner of the mandala. In the centre of the mandala is Shakyamuni Buddha, on his right is Arya Avalokitesvara with 6 consorts- Pandaravasini, Tara, Bhrikuti, Prajnaparamita, Locana, Ushnisharaja.(p.40, *Manjusri Mulakalpa Part-I*(1920), edited by T. Ganapati Sastri, Trivandrum).

In the fourth chapter of the MMK, she is described in detail. She is worshipped as the destroyer of fear. (Ibid. pp.65-66)

In the 53rd Chapter of the MMK, which appears to be an addition during 10th or early 11th century, there are passages referring to the praise of Tara by Candragomin. In the chapter, Tara is said to be the Goddess of the eastern region, more particularly east of Varanasi. She is said to be of Samudrakula(belonging to the lineage of seas)(p.647, *MMK Part -3*, Edited by T. Ganapati Sastri, 1925). She rules the banks of the rivers and more particularly the Ganga. She is worshipped at Harikela, Karma-Ranga, Kamarupa and Kalasa (ibid. p.648).

This clarifies the position that Tara worship was introduced into India from the Bay of Bengal route and later she became the popular deity of Eastern India. Harikela is present day Chittagong region, Karmaranga is present day Nakhon Si Thammarat(Nagara Sri Dharmaraja) on the southern shore of the Gulf of Siam at isthmus of Ligor, and Kalasa in Central Java where famous Temple of Tara was built during the 8th century and Kamarupa, where the Kamakhya-pitha is situated.

The name Karmaranga was also given to the Star fruit (carambola) which is found in Southeast Asia and widely used in Ayurvedic preparations. Srivijayan King of Sumatra established foothold at Karmaranga by 775AD and also built several structures dedicated to the Buddha and various Bodhisattvas. Clearly, the authority of Tara was stated to be in the eastern India and coastal belt of the Bay of Bengal till Central Java.

Generally, it is believed that the Guhyasamaja Tantra(GST) was composed after the MMK. Several commentaries on GST are available- tantric Nagarjuna(615 AD), Shantideva(695AD), Krishnacarya(717 AD), Lilavajra(741 AD), Ratnakarshanti(978 AD). In all likelihood these dating processes need to be further corrected. GST is clearly based

upon the formulations in MMK and MMK itself is refinement over *Mahavairocana Sutra*. An outline of the eighteen sections of the GST is said to be noted in the *Chih-kang-ting-ching-yii-chHeh-shih-pa-lui-chih-kuei* as translated into Chinese by Amoghavajra who had been in India between 744 and 746 A.D. Further, the name “Guhyasamaja-yoga” and a brief explanation of this text appears in the fifteenth section of the *Shih-pa-lui-chin-kuei*. Thus, it is clear that the tantra was being practised before 746 A.D. in secret assemblies (Guhyasamaja). Padmasambhava, who was active during the same period in Tibet and Himalayan belt has not referred to any text on GST, but he was an adept in the Guhyasamaj Yoga. It is likely that the practise was still passed on orally and the text could have been composed after disappearance of Padmasambhava sometimes in the first decade of the 9th century.

GST, introduced for the first time, the element of full fledged Sakti worship in Buddhism. Until the Mahayana form of Buddhism, it was said that Enlightenment can be attained only through a male form.

In the *Guhyasamaj Tantra*, the five skandhas (aggregates) were deified as five Dhyani Buddhas- Vairocana for Form (Rupa), Ratnasambhava for Feeling (Vedana), Amitabh for Perception (Samjna), Amoghasiddhi for impression (Samskara) and Akshobhaya for Consciousness (Vijnana). In Chapter 17 of the GST, five Shakti as deification of five elements (dhatus) has been described, Locana is for earth element (Prithvi), Mamaki for water element (Apya), Pandara for Fire element (Teha), Tara for wind element (Vayu) and Samya for space element (Vajradhara). These five Shaktis also represent five Kulas- moha (delusion), dvesha (hate), chintamani (wish-fulfilling gem), Raga (attachment), samaya (disciplining of passion). In the GST, Tara is linked to Amoghasiddhi, Pandara to Amitabha, Mamaki to Ratnasambhava, Locana to Vairocana and Vajradhatiswari to Akshobhaya,

In chapter 14 of the GST, the mahamantra of Tara- *Om Tare tuttare Ture svaha*- has been mentioned. Thus, it is clear that by the composition of the GST text, the seed syllable as well as the mantra of the Goddess Tara was finally settled among the proponents.

Taranatha (b.1575-), Tibetan scholar and historian of Buddhist Tantras in India has also composed the history of dissemination of Tara worship. In 1604, he composed the Golden rosary recounting the history of Tara worship in Tibet. *The Golden Rosay: A History Illuminating The Origin of the Tantra of Tara*, has three sections- period of earlier dissemination upto King Dharmapala, thence suppression by King Dharmapala and the later dissemination beginning with Tilopa.

Dharmapala occupied the throne from c.781-821 A.D. Tilopa's period is calculated from Tibetan sources to be between 928-1009 AD.

Taranatha describes how King Harichandra in Bengal, King Munja in Odisha (Odisha), King Bhojadeva of Malwa and King Haribhadra in Konkana and their retinues attained the siddhi practising Tara tantra. This is clearly after demise of Dharmapala, son of Gopala who ruled from Somapaura in Naogaon. Dharmapala conquered Varanasi and Prayaga. He also

established Vikramshila Mahavihara. Taranatha mentions how the Tara Tantra was suppressed by King Dharamapala. His son, Devapala(821-861 AD) established his capital at Monghyr. The Tantra revived. But, it appears that the Tantra peaked during the reign of Mahipala I(995-1043 AD). He was contemporary of King Bhoja, Candras and likely to be of Konkanai King, Haribhadra who is mentioned in Taranath's History of Buddhism in India having attained siddhi in preparing magical pills(alchemy). Mahipala's name has been found in the Manjushri Mulakalpa in the Chapter 53, which is written as a prophecy, but clearly a later day insertion. In this whole long section, Tara is described as the Goddess governing Eastern kingdoms.

We can thus arrive at a consensus that during the latter half of 10th century and the first half of 11th century, the cult of Tara had spread far and wide from Eastern India to western coast of Konkana and eastern islands of Java.

It is during this stage that Tilopa appears on the scene. Tilopa's disciple Naropa(956-1040) was a great Pandita of Nalanda. Dipamkara Srijnana Atisha(980-1054 AD) who was initiated by Naropa popularised the cult of Tara in Tibet upon his arrival in 1042 AD. But, even before Atisha's propagation of Tara worship in Tibet, Tibetan royalty was conversant with the Goddess Tara. The Licchavi Princess Bhrikuti Devi, is traditionally considered to have been the first wife of the earliest emperor of Tibet, Songtsen Gampo (604 - 650 CE). While she took a statue of Tara made from sandalwood, the other consort of the King, Wencheng Gongzhu, a Tang princess brought image of Avalokiteshwara. This statue is now housed in the Jokhang in Lhasa and the statue of Tara was installed in the temple at Ramoche, which no longer exists. Both have been eulogized as incarnation of Tara- Bhrikuti Devi as incarnation of Green Tara and Wencheng as incarnation of White Tara.

This indicates that the statue of Tara was considered a very special gift by the first half of seventh century. The devotion to Goddess Tara was becoming popular.

The popularity of Tara worship appear to have picked pace with the advent of grammarian Candragomin(~600-650 AD). Candragomin was born in the Kingdom of Varendra(northern Bengal). He was married to the King's daughter, Tara. But when he realized that it was improper to have wife with the name of his tutelary deity, he deserted his wife. The King became angry and got him sealed and thrown in the Ganges. Candragomin prayed to Goddess Tara and he was rescued. He landed upon island, which was named as Candradwipa. Candragomin thence visited Singhala(Sri Lanka) and propagated the path of devotion towards Tara. He came through Sri Parvata and Potala in Andhra to Nalanda. Once in Nalanda, his stories of miracles spread far and wide. He was also a great grammarian and composed Candra Vyakaran. Debate between Candragomin and Candrakirti, Nalanda's Acarya went on for seven years and well documented in Buddhist intellectual history.

In the account of travels of Chinese pilgrim, Xuanzang(602-664 AD), we find how the worship of Tara was already prevalent in Nalanda premises. Xuanzang visited India from 630-646 AD. He arrived in Nalanda in 636 AD and stayed for two years and again returned for second time in 642 AD before leaving India in 643 AD. Xuanzang mentions how a tall statue of Tara(Ta-Lo) Bodhisattva was offered perfume and flowers during the festival by the

royalty at Nalanda premise (Book IX,p.174 Si-Yu-Ki, Buddhist records of The Western world,Vol. II trans. Samuel Beal, 1884). Similarly, in Book VIII, he mentions about a Tara statue alongwith Bodhisattva Avalokiteshvara in Tiladaka monastery(telahara), west of Nalanda. Xuanzang did mention about Indian Candra in the list of scholars who resided in Nalanda premises. Along with Dharmapala(Hu-fa), he lists Candra(Hu-Yue). Yue is the name of bright shining moon in Chinese and Hu is a pejorative term used for the barbarians including Indians.

Since *Manjusri-mula-Kalpa* eulogises Candra for his devotion towards Tara, it is safe to assume that the worship of Tara was introduced by Candragomin in Nalanda premises.

The cult of Tara spread far and wide from the centre of Nalanda across Asia. Newarese carried it to Nepal, and through the sea route, it spread to East Asia. It also spread on the western coast of India, particularly Konkana and the great paintings of Ajanta, Ellora, Kanheri devoted to Goddess Tara were sanctioned by the believers.

We can thus arrive at a consensus that during the later half of 10th century and the first half of 11th century, the cult of Tara had spread far and wide from Eastern India to western coast of Konkana and eastern islands of Java.

Tara of Candradwipa to Tara of Kalasan

Candradwipa is modern day Sandwip island in Bakarganj in southern Bangladesh. This is a vast crescent shaped island facing the Chittagong coast. Candragomin is believed to have lived on this island. There was a famous Tara temple on the island which finds mention in the *Sadhnamala* composed during 1165 AD. The method of worshipping the Candradwip Tara has been described in this compendium of worship of Vajrayana deities. In Taranath's account on origin of Tara worship, Candragomin's devotion has been highly extolled. Candragomin was also a great grammarian having composed *Chandra Vyakaran* that became a major tool for Buddhist scholars in coming centuries. Candragomin is believed to have composed his hymns for Tara while living here. Candradwipa finds mention in copper plates of Sricandra and the chroniclers write that Tailokyacandra became the King of Candradwipa. Some Chinese chronicles mention about the temple of Tara in the south sea during 1015 AD. The Tara temple of Candradwipa is no more. But, there are still Vajrayogini temples in the Sandwip islands. There is likelihood that when the island was Islamized, the statue was moved to the adjacent Chatargram(Chittagong) and from where the same was taken by the Candra Kings(Dhanya Manika Candra) to Udaipur in present day Tripura and now popularly known as the Tripura Sundari temple. The statue is known as Magadheswari, the goddess of Magadha. We have seen how Tara has been described as the ruler of eastern region and Nalanda Mahavihara in Magadha being the centre of dissemination of the cult of Tara.

Manjushri Mula Kalpa further mentions about Tara worship in Kalasa. Kalasa is the old Sanskrit name of Kalasan in Central Java.

The Tara Temple at Kalasan is a remarkable structure in Yogyakarta Special Region of Central Java. Its height is 34 metre(72 hasta) and has a square base of 45 metre(96 hasta). Kalasan inscription of 778A.D. (D-147, National Library of Indonesia) mentions about its construction.

The inscription in Sanskrit language mentions how the temple of Tara was ordered to be built by the teachers of the Sailendra King as an ornament of the Sailendra dynasty. The approval for the construction was granted by the Sanjaya King, Panapana Panamkarna. The Kalasa village was given to the Sangha.

The homage in the inscription describes Tara as one who looks down at the world and is the only guiding star for direction in this world(Naraloka) and the divine realm(Indra loka) . She is the Jagad Eka Tara .. single star of the world.

It was at this temple that Dipamkara Srijna Atisha meditated over Goddess Tara during his 12 year sojourn to Java to receive teachings from Dharmapala(Serelingpa in Tibetan accounts).

Tara temple at Candradwipa and Tara temple at Kalsan reveals how closely tara was associated with the sea farers and how it was known as the Goddess belonging to the oceanic lineage(samudra-kula) in the Manjusri- Mula-Kalpa.

Is Goddess Tara the deification of the Pole star, the Ekatarā(single star) that guides the terrestrial as well as the heavenly world?

(To be contd)

Niraj Kumar is completing five volume translation and commentary on Kalacakra Tantra.He is based in Delhi.

Touch of Heaven and Other Poems



(Ambika Talwar)

Music is dead; weight lifts my body in so many way.
My begging palms open year after year
looking at heaven where I, a fool, wish to crawl.

My feet, cracked from walking miles
of this trembling earth
who has not stopped dancing,
long for your hands — a caress
like that of rain hugging in puddles
squishy tenderness swallowing skylight.
Ah, just the music my body longs for.

Oh but what heaven, if you
would play these notes on my skin,
I would not have to crawl so far.

—
Found Fragment of Time
Precious things are lonely.
Is such vision true?
A little tourmaline rock
clings to grass
out in wild Manzanita.

More than any place
that I have seen
this ruin
in a dotted landscape
has a strange melody
a displaced Wuthering...

Blowing over brush, wind reminds
possibilities are endless.

A sudden drop
into the wild rocks,
I lose my balance –
I trip slipping on pebbles into
a profusion of white

a lost shirt torn dirty
strip of rag is wound around
clump of white daisies...
Who was here?

Muddied scrap of paper
peers from the wee shade
of timid petals:

this vision is true
 how we reflect on
 architecture of things
 all same are... 3 into 1

bees ... honeycomb
 non-duality of all
 how ... cursed... the sea
 wild blue sea...

Sharp blue drop – ragged
 cliff falling into vast black hole
 hangs in my face...

When Fire Meets Fire

Under dappling shade of trees
 where sun fell with gentling gaze
 and nothing scorched my skin,
 we smiled about bad hair days;
 he never has bad hair days.

My new friend is in the midst
 of refashioning his destiny.
 He tenderly laughed at
 my words about adoration.
 We sang songs of praise.

We waited for the agni kund to come alive
 with fire so we could surrender
 our herbs tied in cloth

for divine grace to do her part.

A devotee added kindling to the pit.

He said, “You can place your sankalpa here.”

“I don’t want it to smother in smoke,” I said.

I’d rather it burn in the fire.”

Grey swirls were thickly rising

as patterns of swift change.

Petite lovely woman in green sari

Chimed in, “Fire is everywhere.”

“So am I,” I twinkled.

My friend sat down on white sheet

beside the pit – Fire was awake,

inviting us all to a dance...

Watching his inner being in prayer pose

his eyes closed, my heart’s doors trembled

to its luminous field, a well-watered seed

fully awaking to pride of air.

I knew instantly to meet fire with fire.

To deny fire is: to forgo all desire,

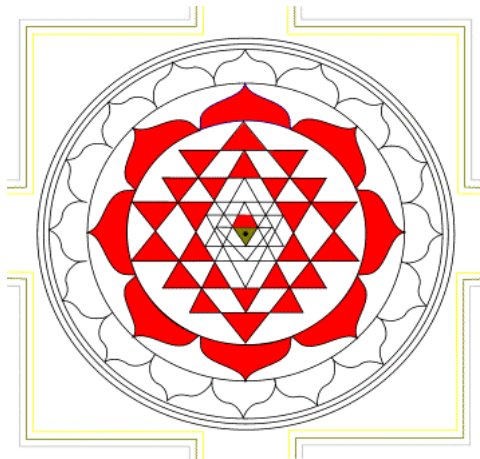
to make life smother in grey plumes,

to avoid surrender.

Fire gazing into fire – simply adoration.

Let us all adore one another –!

Ambika Talwar teaches creative arts in the US. Her poetry has an underlying streamline of mystic consciousness inspired by eastern metaphysics.



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